Westbrook Planning Board

~ Planning Board Meeting ~

Date: Tuesday, May 19, 2026
Time: 7:00 PM
Location: Westbrook High School (Room 114), 125 Stroudwater St. (Hybrid via Zoom)
Video: https://vimeo.com/1193769024
Packet: https://www.westbrookmaine.gov/AgendaCenter/ViewFile/Agenda/_05192026-1004

Timestamps below are clickable [0:00]-style links — they jump straight to that moment in the video.

This summary highlights the meeting's key discussions and decisions, with direct quotes and timestamps for verification — it is not a substitute for watching the full meeting. *This meeting continued an item not reached on May 5. For complete context, nuance, and anything not covered here, watch the full video at the link above. (Produced by: WestbrookCurrents.com)*

I. Roll Call

Roll Call [2:55]

Discussion Summary

Chair Larry McWilliams called the meeting to order, noting it continues business from May 5. Roll call: five of nine seated members present (McWilliams, Lucas Schrage, Oriana Farnham, Robin Tannenbaum, and Vice Chair John Turcotte) — a bare quorum; Kevin Price, Nancy Litrocapes, Jason Frazier, and Karen Axelson absent.

Key Decisions

✓ Quorum established.

Action Items

None.

Workshop — Rock Row South Campus Building SG & SR (26-000274)

[3:48] Ian McKim (Jones & Beach Engineers), Amanda (Aero Street, presenting landscape work for Spacecraft), and Tim Reagan (Amenta Emma Architects) presented the first individual site plan from the Rock Row Phase 3 master plan reviewed in April: a 7-story parking garage with ground-level retail and an interior transit hub (Building SG) paired with a 6-story, ~276-unit residential building wrapping a central courtyard (Building SR). The garage provides about 700 spaces serving the broader Phase 3 campus, with a planned pedestrian connection back to Phase One through the former amphitheater parking area.

Architecturally, the team described drawing on the adjacent quarry's rock-cutting imagery, using a charcoal-and-wood-tone palette and deliberate vertical facade breaks to reduce the visual scale of what may be one of the largest buildings ever built in Westbrook; ground-floor retail (roughly six storefronts near the residential building, three more near the garage) wraps the street frontage, including a small public “third place” gathering space between the residential and retail portions, responsive to the board's earlier master-plan

feedback. City Planner Rebecca Spitella noted the South Campus has been subdivided into several parcels, each coming before the board individually; the next parcel is expected in June. No public comment was offered.

Vice Chair John Turcotte [33:41] asked how the garage's spaces would be allocated and about the adjacent flooded quarry pit's water level (the applicant: water has risen about 150 feet since a 2014 survey, with roughly 30–40 feet left before active pump management is needed, likely a couple of years off) and praised the massing effort for such a large building. Member Lucas Schrage [38:07] praised the wood-tone material choice and echoed interest in complimentary parking for residents. Member Oriana Farnham [39:00] raised a pointed concern that the planned transit hub might primarily serve luxury residents rather than the lower-income neighbors who actually rely on the existing, poorly-served Route 4 bus stop nearby, and pushed for complimentary parking and smaller retail spaces to help attract local businesses. Member Robin Tannenbaum [43:55] echoed skepticism that Rock Row's retail mix trends national, worried new stops could slow the existing bus loop, and suggested a free shuttle to Market Basket. Chair McWilliams [46:26] praised the dual vehicle access points, asked about garage monitoring for abandoned vehicles, and suggested commissioning local murals to soften the garage facade.

Key Decisions

No vote — workshop item. The applicant will return in June with the next Rock Row South Campus parcel.

Planner's Business — Community Growth & Development Trends (Informational)

[52:06] Prompted by concerns raised at the May 5 meeting, City Planner Rebecca Spitella presented data on school enrollment and traffic impact trends, while previewing several large applications expected in June: 500 Spring Street (the former Twin Falls golf course site, now ~228 units), 688–712 Main Street (final review), 955 Bridgton Street (new), and Millbrook Estates (a Westbrook Housing development on East Bridge Street, returning as a workshop).

A ten-year chart of Planning Board approvals versus building permits showed 2022–2023 as peak years, with growth up overall compared to a roughly 70-units-per-year average from 2006–2016; not every approved project is built on schedule, and large projects typically take two to three years from approval to construction. Regionally, Westbrook's growth rate trails neighboring Windham and Scarborough. On schools, HUD housing-type data (2018–2024) showed a balanced mix (34% single-family, 14% duplex, 53% multifamily, with multifamily skewing smaller/less likely to house school-age children), and district enrollment has stayed essentially flat despite housing growth; Spitella cautioned the often-cited 2016 school impact study significantly overprojected current enrollment (predicting ~2,885 students against actual enrollment near 2,377).

> *“Looking at the development that we've had and looking at the numbers we've had, we haven't gotten to a point where that development is really impacting an enrollment number.”*

— City Planner Rebecca Spitella [1:09:30]

Vice Chair John Turcotte [1:03:41] added that McKinney-Vento data (tracking housing-insecure students) in Westbrook schools has risen sharply since January, suggesting new housing may be stabilizing already-present, housing-insecure families rather than drawing new population into the district. On traffic, Spitella distinguished roadway “capacity” from driver-behavior concerns and explained the tiered review process (a state DOT permit triggers at 100+ peak-hour trips; below that, the City Engineer evaluates mitigation). Chair McWilliams, Vice Chair Turcotte, and member Tannenbaum [1:17:01] pressed on who evaluates the cumulative traffic impact of multiple nearby developments over time; Spitella acknowledged that question falls more to City Engineering and regional planning than to the board's project-by-project review authority.

[1:28:56] Spitella closed by proposing an informal post-construction site visit to a few completed multifamily developments that initially drew significant concern (a 9-unit project on Conant Street, the 10-unit Reese Commons on Christie Way, and a 12-unit development on Micah Drive) so members can see firsthand how such projects look once built and settled. The board expressed strong interest, tentatively targeting June or July to schedule.

Key Decisions

Informational presentation — no vote.

How this was made

This summary was produced from the meeting video (linked above, hosted on the City's Vimeo showcase). The audio was downloaded with Downie 4 and transcribed with speaker diarization using MacWhisper. Claude (Anthropic's AI) cross-checked names against the official Planning Board roster, attributed speakers from context (introductions, roll-call order, direct address by the Chair) rather than the raw diarization labels alone, and drafted this summary and the quoted excerpts. Quotes are lightly cleaned of filler words/false starts but not reworded. Review tier: Not reviewed.

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